While avoiding multilateral diplomacy at the United Nations, India also went on a diplomatic blitzkrieg between May and July, sending special envoys and informal representatives to capitals around the world. This effort enjoyed only mixed results. Despite the absence of diplomatic relations, Israel agreed to provide arms to India that were in turn supplied to the Mukti Bahini. [12] In October and November, Indira Gandhi went herself to Western capitals, and her tour included interactions with the media, during which she pressed India's—and Bangladesh's—case.

The year 1971 was also a case of India's soft power proving highly effective. Partially informed by positive sentiments for India and Indian culture, journalists, artists, and musicians in the West spoke out sympathetically for the Bangladesh cause. The best example was the Concert for Bangladesh organized at Madison Square Garden in New York by former Beatles guitarist George Harrison, which featured the likes of Bob Dylan and Eric Clapton. The event, which was initiated by Indian sitarist Ravi Shankar, raised funds for Bangladesh relief and increased public awareness by showcasing documentary footage of atrocities and refugee conditions. While many Western governments remained critical of India, the growing public perception in their countries was that a genocide was underway in East Pakistan. [13] The creation of Bangladesh as an independent country became an increasingly acceptable outcome.

By November 1971, conflict had essentially broken out on the East Pakistan border, one that involved armour, artillery, and aircraft. On 5 December, Pakistan opted for pre-emptive air strikes on India from the west, and this proved a fatal miscalculation. That evening, Indira Gandhi authorized Army Chief General Sam Manekshaw to go to war in the east. India benefited from larger forces in the theatre, control of airspace and the sea, and better intelligence and logistics. But believing that the capital Dhaka was too difficult to take, Indian war plans initially envisaged seizing large tracts of territory in the east, installing a Bangladeshi government, and using this leverage to force a political resolution with Pakistan. Plans changed between 9 and 11 December, when Indian forces from the east successfully reached the Meghna River. Without the means to cross the